World War II of Lebanon's Muslim population, nor that this would lead to civil war.

The rainbow of ancient antagonisms in the Middle East produced an instability that the Soviet Union spent decades and billions seeking to exploit. To Libya, Syria, and the PLO, Moscow and its allies in the Eastern bloc became eager suppliers of arms that were used not only to keep the Middle East pot boiling but also to foment terrorism in other parts of the world. Under President Hafez el-Assad, Syria had become virtually a Soviet satellite in the Middle East, its army supplied and trained by the Soviets. Russian money, arms, and influence were showing up throughout the region.

During the 1970s and early 1980s, the rapid spread in Iran and elsewhere of the most fanatical varieties of Islamic fundamentalism, with their goal of toppling secular governments and replacing them with theocracies modeled after Iran's, made the Middle East even more unpredictable, giving the Soviets new opportunities to exploit the instability there. In a region whose oil exports were essential to the West, Soviet meddling was something the United States could not tolerate, and all our presidents since World War II, including me, felt an obligation to help reduce the instability and bring about peace.

I've believed many things in my life, but no conviction I've ever held has been stronger than my belief that the United States must ensure the survival of Israel.

The Holocaust, I believe, left America with a moral responsibility to ensure that what had happened to the Jews under Hitler never happens again. We must not let it happen again. The civilized world owes a debt to the people who were the greatest victims of Hitler's madness.

My dedication to the preservation of Israel was as strong when I left the White House as when I arrived there, even though this tiny ally, with whom we share democracy and